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UK launches £500M
package to support
diverse,
underrepresented
investors and founders



The British Business Bank (BBB), owned by the U.K. government, is creating a £500 million (around \$674 million) [economic package to help](#) support diverse and underrepresented fund managers and founders in the country.

Fifty million pounds will be set aside for female-led venture funds, which means the BBB has now committed at least £100 million (around \$135 million) to supporting female-led ventures and the government's [Invest in Women Taskforce](#).

Meanwhile, £400 million (around \$539 million) will go to backing more diverse fund managers and ~~supporting early-stage companies~~, as well as helping to boost the talent pipeline to provide those from disadvantaged backgrounds the opportunity to become investors. The package begins deployment in 2026.

“The initiative announced today aims to reduce the significant gap in venture capital investment for underrepresented founders and investors,” the BBB said in a press release announcing the investment last week. “It will target at least 50% of investment going to female fund managers.”

It comes as the U.K. continues its push to attract and sustain talent to its venture ecosystem. The press release states that “breaking down barriers to opportunity will help drive growth as part of the government’s Plan for Change,” which

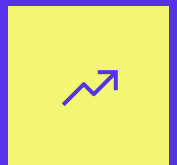
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encompasses various strategies to help drive economic growth in the country.

For women and people of color, the U.K. venture landscape can often be as disheartening as it is in the U.S. Around 13% of venture teams in the U.K. have women at a senior level, while dismal amounts of venture funding goes to minorities — [less than 2% for Black founders](#) as of a 2023 report, and 2 pence (around 3 cents) for every £1 (\$1.35) invested goes to women.

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Dominic-Madori Davis

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Cornerstone VC hires Ella Wales Bonner as first female partner

Dominic-Madori Davis — 3:59 AM PDT · July 5, 2023

[Cornerstone VC](#), one of the [leading funds](#) in the U.K. with a diversity-led investment thesis, announced today the hiring of its latest partner: [Ella Wales Bonner](#).

She will be the fund's first female partner and will also focus time on building Cornerstone's mentoring practice to support the founders within the fund's portfolio. As an investor, Wales Bonner tells TechCrunch she's interested in consumer products, or "essentially any product or platform that everyday people can use," she said.

Previously Wales Bonner worked at JamJar Investments and M&C Saatchi and has a history of hosting events for diverse founders within the U.K.'s venture landscape. She believes it's important for a woman of color like her to be visible in the industry so other underrepresented groups know there is

IMAGE CREDITS: CORNERSTONE VC

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capital allocated in 2022.

Wales Bonner's appointment is also important as [more women of color rise](#) through the ranks of venture. She joins Cornerstone at a key moment, with the wider venture market still in the midst of a downturn. Wales Bonner said the fund is still in the early stages, so it is less exposed to inflated valuations as it has yet to deploy vast amounts of capital. Still, she sees this moment as a great opportunity.

"The change in the market means we can spend more time getting to know founders through our investment process," she said. "We are a people-first fund, so having time to foster strong relationships with our portfolio is really important to us."

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Cornerstone invests in pre-seed and seed rounds,
with average check sizes ranging from £250,000 to
£1 million. It is currently investing out of its [£20
million fund](#), which closed in August of last year. It
plans to back up to 40 companies, reserving 40% of
the capital for follow-on investments.

Wales Bonner is overall excited about this next
phase of life. The U.K. is going through a cost-of-
living crisis, plunging many consumers and
businesses into uncertainty and changing how
people think about their work and lives. People want
balance and fulfilment, she said.

“I am still hopeful we will see a new wave of brilliant
businesses being born out of the need for change.”

*This story was updated to reflect Wales Bonner’s
full name and to reference updated stats regarding
the amount of funding given to all-women teams.*

Topics: [Cornerstone](#) [diversity](#) [founders](#) [Startups](#)

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VENTURE

Black founders still raised just 1% of all VC funds in 2022

Dominic-Madori
Davis

8:30 AM PST · January 6,
2023

Some. Good. News.

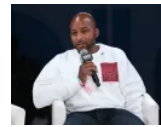
The latest Crunchbase data shows that Black startup founders in the United States raised around \$264 million out of the total \$33.6 billion in venture capital allocated in Q4 2022. That's an uptick from the \$178 million — [or 0.43%](#) — the group raised in Q3.

In total, U.S. Black founders raised an estimated \$2.254 billion out of the \$215.9 billion in U.S. venture capital allocated last year. That's about 1%, a slight drop from the 1.3% raised in 2021. Let's break this down.

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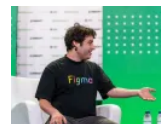


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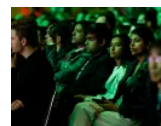
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Data visualization by [Miranda Halpern](#), created with [Flourish](#)

So Black founders in the U.S. picked up around 0.79% of VC funds raised in Q4 2022. There was a

fear that, during a bear market, investors would retreat to their old-school networks, and the total amount of funding Black founders received last year is practically half the amount they raised in 2021 — a record \$4.34 billion (out of around \$330 billion in the U.S. and \$681 billion globally).

Despite the record-breaking 2021, that amount of money equates to just 1.3% of all capital raised in the U.S. alone. No matter what, it seems the actual percentage of the money raised for this cohort barely moves, even as more and more capital floods the markets.

[Tye Calloway](#), the founder of the fintech [Cooler](#), told TechCrunch that it's embarrassing as a Black founder to always be associated with negative statistics, especially as one trying to fundraise.

“It seems like we all know the problem but don't want to solve it when it's as simple as funding more Black founders,” he said. “I know this system wasn't built for us, but when there are billion-dollar markets that cater to Black customers, they should overlook the ignorance and do a bit of research rather than showing zero interest. It's a total uphill battle as a Black founder looking to raise venture capital. But we still do it anyways as the alternatives aren't that much greater for us.”

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[Andy Davis](#), the co-founder of the venture firm
[10x10](#), told TechCrunch that Black founders were
impacted by the economic climate “as the
companies a lot of them worked at were reducing
resources and people.”

“Some Black people had to focus on stability in
their lives before their startups,” he continued. Still,
he said that some “exceptional” Black founders
were able to grow their companies and raise in the
past year.

“The overall climate last year, a lot of funds either
paused, stopped or slowed down their deployment
... impacting all startups, including Black founders
the year before,” Davis said. “I’m highly optimistic
for Black founders this year, especially with the rise
of diverse-led funds and investors.”

There does appear to be a slow change. For
example, in 2016, Black founders raised \$568
million in VC dollars out of around the total \$70
billion allocated to U.S. founders — that was just
0.8%. In 2020, it took Black founders 391 deals to

pick up \$1.301 billion (out of \$164 billion), and in 2022, it took only 225 deals to reach \$2.254 billion, meaning Black founders appear to be raising more money within each individual round.

[De'Havia Stewart](#), an investor at BLCK VC, echoed what many Black investors have told TechCrunch throughout the years: that the decrease in funding to Black founders further highlights a need for more diverse check writers.

“When the macroeconomic environment tumbled, the investors that were preaching D&I disappeared, and their implicit bias became more apparent,” she said.

As Stewart said, what happens next is anyone’s guess. The ball is in the investors’ court. There has been continuous coverage of what needs to occur. All that’s left is for it to happen.

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